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Roots to Resilience

"Roots to Resilience 2050" lays out a phased, system-wide roadmap for transforming Pittsburgh's food landscape from one marked by scarcity and fragmentation into a regenerative, community-owned ecosystem.

In the near term, two shovel-ready interventions jump-start the change: redeveloping disused steel mills into regenerative agriculture hubs, launching a Harvesting Pittsburgh app to knit residents into micro-grant and knowledge-sharing networks, and deploying targeted incentives—tax credits, cooperative ownership structures, and branded “Our Local Produce” channels—to make growing, distributing, and consuming local food economically viable. Parallel household and neighborhood-scale programs (Home Harvest Initiative, Local Harvest Basket, The People’s Table) create immediate access to culturally relevant produce while embedding food-skills education in schools and public spaces.

Mid-term and long-term initiatives deepen these early gains by stitching neighborhood efforts into city, state, and regional-level infrastructure. Farm-to-Institution PA guarantees stable markets for local growers; the Food Sovereignty Wisdom Circle cultivates intergenerational leadership; and an Urban-Rural Food Alliance synchronizes peri-urban farms with city demand, closing loops on supply chains and biodiversity stewardship. Each intervention intentionally maps to Max-Neef's fundamental human needs—subsistence, protection, identity, creation, and participation—while also addressing the social, environmental, and economic levers highlighted in our systems map. By 2050 the portfolio forms a resilient, circular food system that slashes food miles, redirects vacant land into community food forests, and positions Pittsburgh as a model of equitable, hyper-local nourishment and climate adaptation.

Immediate	Mid Term	Long Term
Education	Distribution	Cultivation
		Consumption

Subsistence	Protection	Affection
Understanding	Participation	Idleness
Creation	Identity	Freedom



1. Steel to Sustenance Innovation Hub

2. Harvesting Pittsburgh App
 - Subsistence
 - Participation
3. Urban-Rural Food Alliance
 - Participation
 - Identity
 - Subsistence
 - Protection
4. GrowBack Credit
 - Subsistence
 - Participation
 - Creation
5. Pittsburgh Food Commons Trust
 - Subsistence
 - Protection
6. Food Sovereignty Wisdom Circle
 - Understanding
 - Affection
 - Creation
 - Participation
7. Home Harvest Initiative
 - Subsistence
 - Protection
 - Freedom
 - Creation
8. Cooperative Economy Business Initiative
 - Subsistence
 - Participation
 - Creation
9. Farm-to-Institution Pennsylvania
 - Subsistence
 - Participation
10. The Local Harvest Basket
 - Subsistence
 - Freedom
11. The People's Table
 - Affection
 - Participation
 - Creation
 - Understanding
 - Subsistence
12. "Our Local Produce" Communications Campaign
 - Understanding
 - Identity
13. Food is Freedom Communications Campaign
 - Understanding
 - Identity
14. Root Causes Food Justice Curriculum
 - Understanding
 - Identity
15. Roots & Resilience: Community Food Forests for Cultural and Nutritional Justice
 - Affection
 - Participation
 - Creation
 - Understanding
 - Subsistence